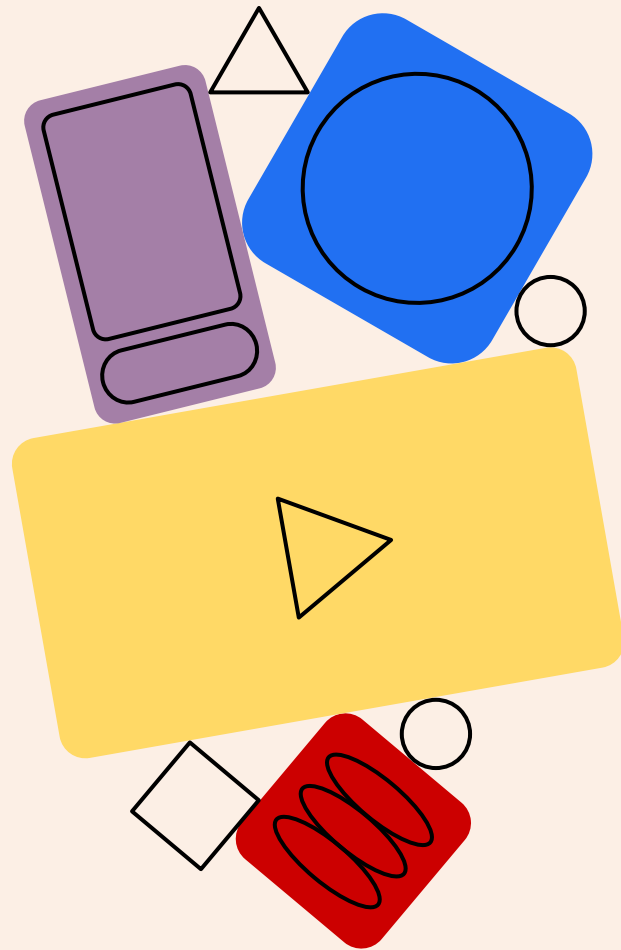


The art of **Active Listening**

Decode feedback, maximize outcomes, and
improve your communication.

By Jenna Lawrence



Learning goal

Create a better way to
apply active listening
in interactions with
stakeholders to improve
project outcomes and
collaboration.

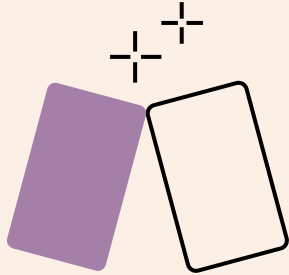
Active listening

The practice of concentrating on what is being said and being fully present without distraction.



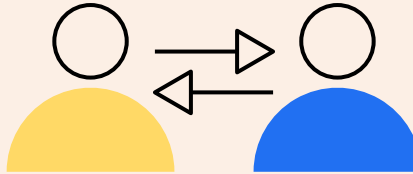
Image source: [Unsplash](#)

Goals of active listening



Connection

Giving full attention to the speaker



Communication

Demonstrating with our body language and behaviours that we are actively listening

Exercise

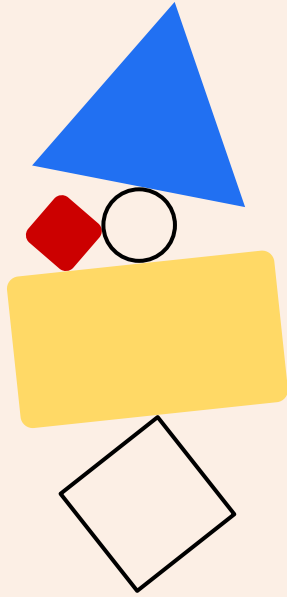


Record a time where you felt unheard while collaborating or conversing with people in your work. How did it make you feel?

Identify the impact that this experience had on project outcomes and relationships with others.

What is one thing that the listener could have done to better demonstrate active listening?

The why



85% of workplace conflicts and misunderstandings stem directly from poor listening and communication practices.

— **Forbes**

Employees spend an average of **5.6** to **7.4** hours per week dealing with the fallout of miscommunication. — **Forbes**

Teams led by managers who demonstrate active listening score **40%** higher in engagement. — **Washington State University**

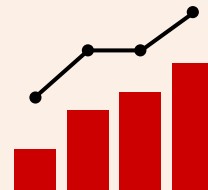
When active listening is formalized, **80%** of projects meet their original target goals. — **Project Management Institute**

Benefits of active listening

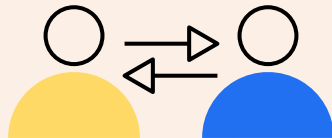
People who apply active listening can anticipate long-lasting benefits.



Writing better requirements



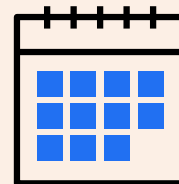
Tracking toward goals



Improving collaboration



Pivoting easily during project timelines



Planning ahead to mitigate risk

What does **good** active listening look like?

Body language:

- Smiling is a way of affirming what is being said
- Making eye contact encourages connecting with the speaker
- Leaning in and slanting your head slightly demonstrates listening
- Mirroring body language shows you are relating to the speaker

Communication:

- Reinforcing positively is used to show attentiveness
- Remembering key points reinforces that the message is being received
- Questioning and clarifying what the speaker has said helps demonstrate listening and comprehension
- Reflecting and paraphrasing what that speaker said demonstrates understanding

What does **bad** active listening look like?

Things to avoid:

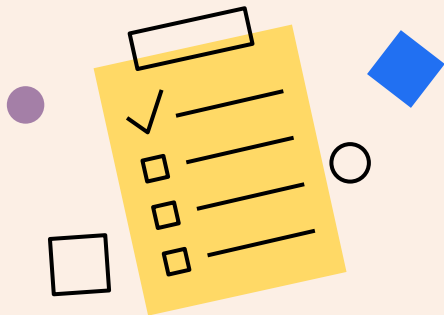
- Being distracted
- Mimicking active listening body language without actually listening
- Listening without taking consideration for what is being shared

The outcomes:

- Gathering poor requirements
- Disrupting discussions
- Limiting our ability to gather feedback
- Building poorly organized roadmaps
- Operating with limited information
- Working within a silo
- Lacking peer collaboration

Exercise

De-escalating conflict with active listening



Step 1

Validate the speaker by using paraphrasing and validation

Step 2

Discover the underlying cause of the conflict using open-ended clarification

Step 3

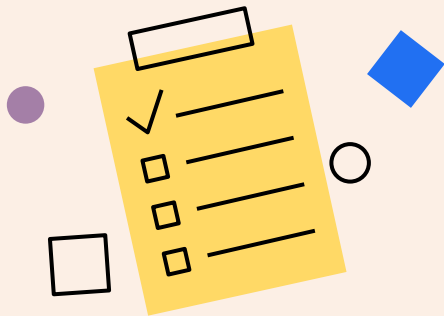
Reflect speaker needs with reflection and summarization

Step 4

Set boundaries by validating speaker needs and then identifying mutually beneficial outcomes

Exercise

De-escalating conflict with active listening



You are note-taking in a research session to help a colleague.

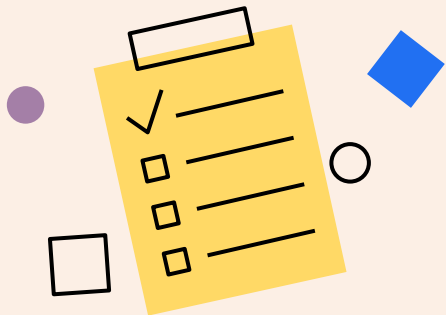
The participant is stressed because they requested support to resolve a long standing issue.

Your colleague, the host of the research session, says “We can cancel the session if this is a bad time.”

You see that communication is breaking down and you must rescue the research session with active listening.

Exercise

De-escalating conflict with active listening



How could you validate the speaker by using paraphrasing?

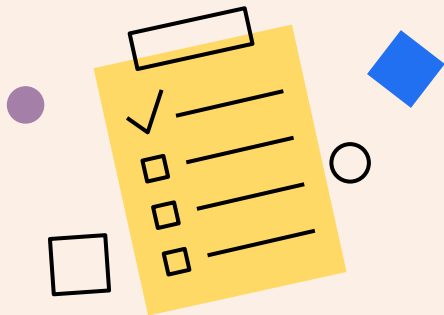
How could you discover the underlying cause of the conflict using clarification?

How could you reflect the speaker's needs?

How could you identify mutually beneficial outcomes for everyone?

Exercise

De-escalating conflict
with active listening

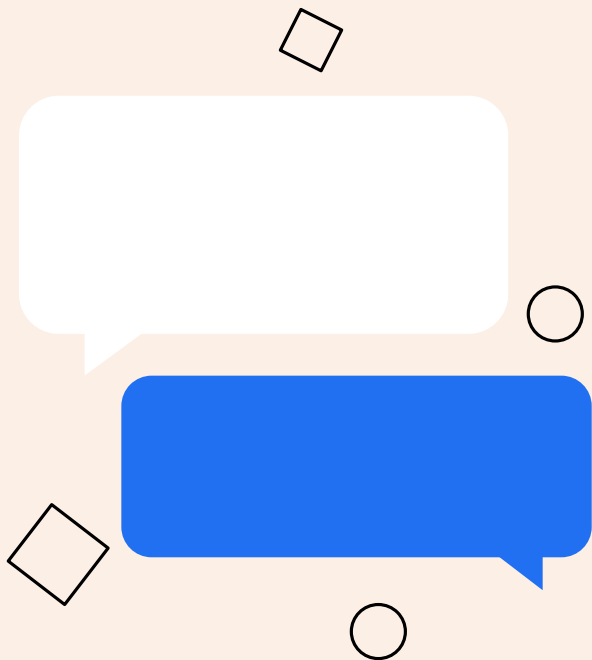


Congratulations!

You've successfully demonstrated active listening.

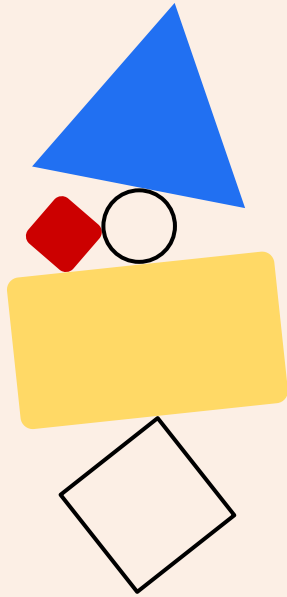
What's next:

- [Writing user stories](#)
- [Team canvas](#)
- [Gathering feedback](#)
- [Roadmapping](#)
- [Contextual inquiry](#)
- [Sharing outcomes](#)



Conclusion

Demonstrating active listening will lead to improved risk mitigation, pivoting, collaboration, goal setting, and outcomes.



Connect

Share your active listening outcomes with us for discussion and feedback.

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domain.com